

Piwik. The latter gives us the liberty to store all the information and Big Data, over which we build a lot of loyalty programmes and event analytics. On the other hand, we use Google Analytics for complete end-to-end analysis of the data. So, I would say we use both technologies, proprietary and open source, depending upon the need."

Community support is bankable...

While some feel that the open source community support is not something that they can vouch for, Mittal believes that it is pretty bankable. She explains, "If you take Pentaho as an example, it has both an enterprise edition, which is proprietary software, as well as a community edition. So, when you go for the community edition, you can ask for anything including extra bug fixes, various kinds of features from forums like Stack Overflows, etc. They maintain their own JIRAs, where you can request for new updates and also add on to them. These things are super beneficial when you are going with an open source model. Another example that I can cite is that of MongoDB. There are multiple support forums available for it, whereas if you go for an Oracle server or an SQL server, there is minimal support and you have to take help from the proprietary software companies for any kind of development issue."

Mittal adds, "There have been many cases when the community came to our rescue. Like in the case of Solr, when we were building our entire search over it, we got help from people who have worked on it. There is immediate support available on forums like Stack Overflows, etc. And since there are a lot of people who have already worked on such projects, the support is faster. In case of Unbx, we do a lot of work with them. Although their source code is closed, they are based on Elastic Search, which is open. So there is a lot of exchange that happens between us. This kind of community support really helps a lot."

There are drawbacks too...

As they say, nothing is perfect and open source technologies are no exception. Mittal has faced some issues as well when she adopted open source technologies. She says, "One of the major factors that one needs to take care of while using any technology, whether open source or proprietary, is that the security standards are maintained and there is no leakage. This goes for open source technologies too. So while you are using OpenCart or Drupal,

you need to do a security review before you take up anything for your project. If you have to deal with data security, then security hardening becomes even more important. This is where proprietary technologies find a place, because they are backed by a company that takes care of these aspects."

Mittal does her homework before she actually gets on to any technology. She says, "We conduct a lot of security checks before taking up any technology. An example that I can quote is that of OpenCart, where we check for SQL injections, DDoS attack protection, server side validation, et al. OpenCart is a CMS based platform, so a lot of front-end JQuery injection and validations have to be taken care of while implementing it. Also, we ensure that data does not go out of our system because of any leakage. We do the necessary security hardening wherever required, before we deploy any technology."

Open source: The first love

When it comes to making a tech choice, open source technology is Mittal's first love. She says, "Before we make a choice, we look for open source solutions and evaluate them first."

Open source is our priority. In start-ups like ours, open source is actually solving about 80-90 per cent of the software problems. Control over costs really matters for a start-up, which is what we are, currently. We always look for open source. Some open source software is actually much better than the enterprise editions available.

"When we have to make a choice, we definitely look at all the possible available options. That is very important to make an informed choice. Like in the case of the reporting tool that we chose, Pentaho, we did evaluate the advantages of the community edition versus the enterprise edition. If we get better support from the enterprise edition, we will choose that over the community edition, and vice versa," she adds.

When asked if finding talent in open source software is a challenge, Mittal explains her recruitment strategy. She says, "I won't deny that we face difficulty in getting talent when we look for in-depth knowledge of open source subjects. But we don't look for technical brilliance all the time. We look for people who are deeply interested in, passionate and knowledgeable about the basic structure of technologies. If they have the right adaptive attitude and knowledge of basic structures, they can move to any technology, whether it is open or closed source." 



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